

7

THE SYNTHESIS OF VISUAL STYLE

In the preceding chapters there is a diversity of point of view about what factors and forces the visual artist and communicator must be familiar with in order to construct, compose, pre-plan any visual material in terms of meaning or mood. Knowledge of shared principles of perception forms a stepping-off point, a base for prediction of the effect of certain visual decisions in the organization of a project. The elements offer the visual communicator the fundamental (and meaning-charged) substance for construction. Categorizing the different levels of visual input and output points the way to intelligent definition of the task and its underlying purpose. The techniques are the enablers, the options for choice that control the results. All together these visual means offer the artist another level of form and content encompassing the personal statement of the individual creator and, beyond that, the shared visual philosophy and character of a group, a culture, a period in history.

STYLE

Style is the visual synthesis of the elements, techniques, syntax, inspiration, expression, and basic purpose. It is complex and difficult to describe with clarity. Maybe the best way to establish the definition in terms of visual literacy is to regard it as a category or class of visual expression shaped by a total cultural environment. For instance, the differences between Oriental and Occidental art are the conventions that govern them. Of the two cultural styles, the Oriental is by far the more conventionalized, that is, legislated by strong rules and basic principles involving generally accepted cultural agreement. In most Japanese art, and, for that matter, life style, there is a deference to "the way." Basically this refers to the way of doing things, whether it is drawing a picture, designing a garden, preparing tea, or writing haiku. The approach to all things assumes high standards, a love of beauty, a devotion on the part of the individual who undertakes the tasks, but the concept of "the way" extends beyond these guidelines given. Its meaning can be best illustrated by describing the rules for writing haiku. The form is rigidly defined. A haiku must have seventeen syllables. No more, no less. No variations are allowed or honored. All choice of technique and individual expression must fit into the prescribed format. It is a convention. But the Japanese not only accept the absolute rules for writing this special kind of poem, they search for freedom within the imposed discipline and seem comfort-

table working within a structure. The results seem no less creative than freer poetic forms that offer subjective options. Indeed, no one could consider the haiku a potential cliché.

Style influences artistic expression in much the same way as conventions do. But stylistic rules are subtler than conventions, exerting on the creative act influence rather than control. Western artistic conventions are freer than Oriental art, yet, nevertheless, the personal style they allow for is contained within the superimposed context of cultural style. Architect Louis Sullivan felt the imposed structure this way: "You cannot express unless you have a system of expression; and you cannot have a system of expression unless you have a prior system of thinking and feeling; and you cannot have a system of thinking and feeling unless you have a basic system of living." The systems of living, for artists as well as all people, are culturally conditioned and the step-by-step definition of the broad categories of visual expression helps to understand the relationship between individual style and the precedence and dominance of cultural style.

There are many names for artistic styles that identify not only a methodology of expression, but also a period in history and a defined geographical locale: Byzantine, Renaissance, Baroque, Impressionist, Dada, Flemish, Gothic, Bauhaus, Victorian. Each name conjures up a series of recognizable visual cues that, put together, encompass the work of many artists as well as a period and a place. The similarity of the work of the Impressionists is seen as one, coherent, related, stylistic group, which in no way disturbs the recognizable individuality of each artist identified within the whole. The Victorian period may not suggest the names of a group of artists all working in the same generalized style, but there is no question that there is a richness of visual referents associated with the name. What makes this so? Each individual group, in its probing for new forms, establishes its own traditions. At the structural level, the search for new forms means experimenting with compositional orchestration of the elements, and the establishing of new traditions and results in a methodology based on choice of manipulative visual techniques. The preferences for method are shared by artists and craftsmen working within a style. It is possible, then, to pick one example from a designated style period and analyze it from the point of view of its elemental structure and the compositional decisions arrived at through the choice of enabling techniques. Refinements and variations of technique can serve to iden-

tify an individual artist's uniqueness of style, but a broad point of view in the analysis will effectively define the style of the entire school or period which encompasses his work.

Impressionism, for one, is a stylistic period associated totally with painting. It was a French school, whose members worked in and around Paris in the mid-nineteenth century. Monet's painting is an example of the elements and techniques that shape and form the entire school (7.1). The Gothic style appears not only in architectural form,

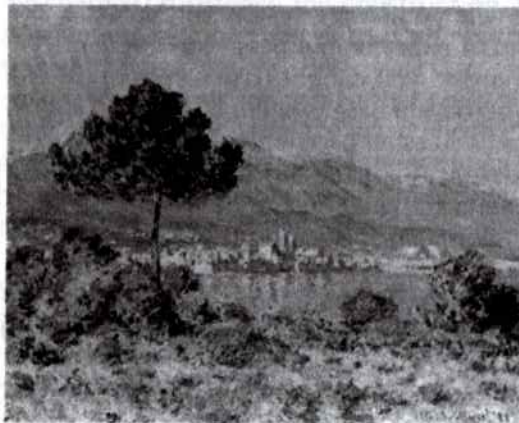


FIGURE 7.1

but also in sculpture, graphics, and crafts. It was spread across northern Europe from France to Germany to England, covering a period of time from the end of the twelfth century through the thirteenth century and, finally into the fourteenth century, a transition period characterized by highly decorated versions of the style. A pure example of Gothic style, and maybe the most famous, is the cathedral at Chartres (7.2). Again, the specific example serves as one of a class that takes so much of its form and content from the choice of techniques in its composition.

Naming a style or a school of visual expression is a great historical convenience for easy identification and reference (7.3), but in contemporary times there has been a fragmentation of nomenclature that has accelerated into a state of absurdity. From op to pop to top (ogographical), the shifting of names has evolved into an almost daily occurrence, an expression unto itself. True, individuality of work is not only desirable but an inevitability for all people. Every human



FIGURE 7.2

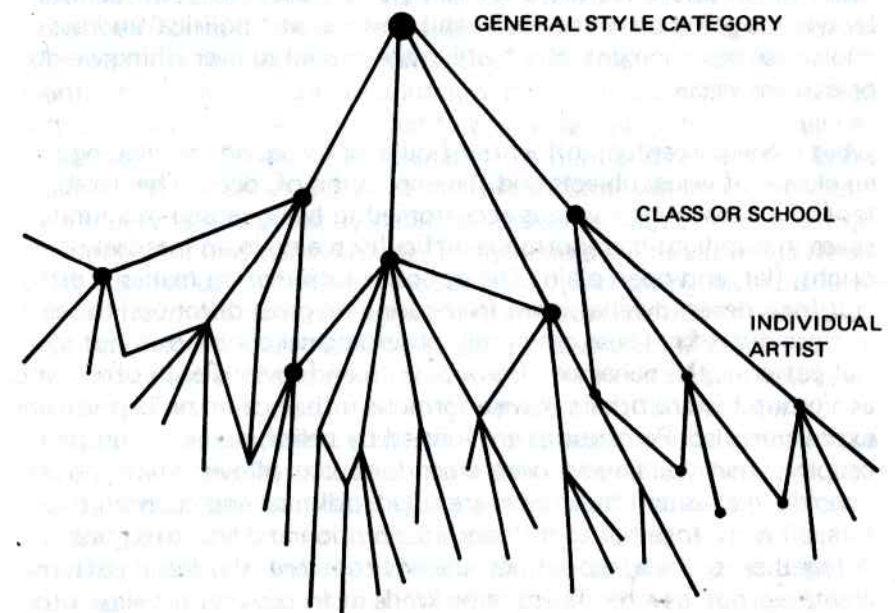


FIGURE 7.3

has a unique face, a unique thumbprint, a unique scanning pattern, and every human being would, if asked to draw a circle, produce a unique circle. And yet, grouping in style does appear in the analysis of a period in history, visually as well as philosophically. Not only

does the work of individual artists naturally group together based on the relationships of media, method, and techniques, but stylistic groups, in the same way, can relate to each other because of the similarities of form and content, even though they are widely separated in time and space, historically and geographically.

Style, in the visual arts, is the ultimate synthesis of all the forces and factors, the coming together, the annealing of many decisions and steps. At the first level is the choice of medium, and the influence of the medium on the form and content. Then, there is the purpose, the reason why something is being made: for survival, for communication, for self-expression. The actual making presents a series of options: the search for compositional decisions by means of choice of elements and recognition of elemental character; the manipulation of the elements through the choice of appropriate techniques. The final result is an individual (or sometimes group) expression monitored by many of the above factors, but mainly and most deeply, influenced by what is going on in the social and physical and political and psychological environment, all of which are crucial to everything we do or express visually.

What is the perceptual influence of outside forces on the making of all classes of visual objects and the expression of ideas? The inhabitant of a dense jungle who is accustomed to being closed in a limited space in dim light has enormous difficulty seeing in an intensely bright, flat, and open plain. The opposite formulation makes it difficult for a desert dweller, used to focusing on great distances, to see in close quarters. These are purely physiological conditions, but social patterns, the behavior of groups with and toward each other, and, as a group toward others, have enormous influence on perception and expression also. Perceptions are formed by belief, religion, and philosophy; what you believe has tremendous control over what you see. The ruling class and those who are ruled, political and economic factors, all work together to influence perception and shape expression. Altogether, politics, economics, the environment, the social patterns create a group psyche. These same kinds of forces that develop into individual languages in verbal usage, combine in the visual mode into a shared style of expression.

Almost all the products of the visual arts and crafts in man's history can be related to five broad categories of visual style: primitive, expressionistic, classical, embellished, functional. Lesser style periods

and schools relate in character to one or a few of these all-encompassing categories. To understand and accomplish these categorizations, it is necessary to rise above stereotyped labeling to a level of archetypal definition. For instance, man's earliest attempts to record and transmit information in the cave paintings of southern France and northern Spain are frequently called primitive. As E. H. Gombrich says in *The Story of Art*: "not because they are simpler than we are—their processes of thought are often more complicated than ours—but because they are closer to the state from which all mankind emerged."

PRIMITIVISM

Since all that remains of the primitive man's purpose when he created drawings 30,000 years ago are the drawings themselves, we can only conjecture about their purposes. To such men the animals in their environment were at once a mortal threat to them and at the same time, their means of survival. For the most part, it was these animals that were the chief subject matter of their work. Why did they draw them, deep in the winter caves, high on the walls? Some possibilities are more favored than others. One of the qualities of the cave paintings is their realism, an unnatural quality in primitive art, which suggests that they were intended to be a visual aid, a hunting manual composed to recreate the problems of the hunt and refresh the knowledge of the hunter as well as to instruct those as yet inexperienced. This theory is supported by details of drawings with arrows pointing to vital organs and vulnerabilities of the animals. The drawings were amazingly lyrical of line, really quite lovely, indicating that it is likely that they were done with great love and appreciation of the animals represented. Our thirty-centuries-old cave dweller might, indeed, share some of the nostalgia for his fellow creepers as well as a memory of warmer seasons when game was plentiful and so was the food supply. It is possible that these works are from the hands of the society's first Sunday painters, and it should be noted they have great beauty and, by any standards of art, are extraordinarily sophisticated. But the threatening environment presented to primitive man unanswerable questions, and not unlike most men so beset, these drawings must have had some relationship to the mysteries he was attempting to understand and contain and therefore must have served in some way a quasi-religious purpose.

Certainly the animal, along with other objects from nature common to the environment, appears prominently in primitive religions, expressing the mystical power men attached to them. Animal symbols,

called totems, differ in many ways from the cave-drawn animals. For one thing, their social purposes are more complex. Along with their religious significance, they also serve purposes of law, prohibiting incest in the simple social systems of preliterate men by making clearer family attachment of the group sharing the same totem. Clan totems took on a scientific purpose when they were used to identify the relationship of star clusters in the sky and their changing positions in the different seasons. Eventually the totems in the zodiac served as man's first calendar. These are the astrological symbols we are born under, and which some people still follow as highly significant indications of their personality and even destiny.

The only valid way to categorize these prehistoric drawings is to try to define primitive as a style, based on purpose and techniques. Primitive art and design is stylistically unsophisticated, that is, it has not developed techniques for replicating natural visual information realistically. In fact, it is a style rich in "symbols" with strongly attached meaning, and for this reason, may have a great deal more to do with the development of writing than visual expression. A sequence in the variation of the recording of visual information can be delineated, which may clarify a great deal of the ambiguous language of the visual arts. The cave painting is man's attempt to look at nature and mark it down as realistically as possible. This is drawing done by some member of the tribe with a particular ability to express what he sees graphically. It is an ability not enjoyed by all his peers. His drawing, then, becomes a language everyone can understand but not everyone can speak. The totem is usually an abstraction from nature, a simplification embodying the essence of the object. This abstract symbolization of nature can be reproduced by anyone; this is a language anyone can understand and everyone can speak. One step further is the symbol that has no connection with any object in the environment, which holds coded information and can be negotiated by anyone, like letters or numbers, but must be learned, since its meaning has been arbitrarily attached to it.

Considering that any form of literacy, that is, system of writing, is unlikely for a primitive people, it is not surprising that there is such richness of symbolism. The symbol is characteristically the shorthand of visual communication and wherever it is used, especially in primitive art, it channels great informational energy from the creator to the audience. Other aspects of primitive art reinforce these qualities of in-



tensification of meaning. Simplicity of shape, in fact, simplicity, is a prime visual technique of the style. Flatness of rendition is also a frequently noticable technique in primitive visual work, as are primary colors. The sum total of all these techniques is a kind of childlike quality in the primitive style, which has some importance to the synthesis of this style. Anton Ehrenzweig so values this approach that he says in *The Hidden Order of Art*: "nothing less than the young child's unconcern for aesthetic detail and his headlong rush for the syncretistic whole will do." What Ehrenzweig means by "syncretistic" is a kind of purposeful neglect of detail toward an end of grasping the meaning in the total object. In primitive art, in the visual work of

children, as in many other art forms, syncretistic vision is a powerful and intense means of expression. A caricature is an example of the manipulation of reality of parts of a human face which altogether is more like the person depicted than a realistic portrait can show. Why? Because the unique characteristics are exaggerated and the result short-circuits the most important information available directly to the perceptions of the observer.

We judge the work of children and primitives as crude, but before we accept this judgment, we should reevaluate the work on the basis of its purpose. Appropriateness has great effect on any visual work, and the intensity and purity of this style should be given its due.

Every visual style draws its character and appearance from the visual techniques applied, whether consciously by the highly trained artist and artisan or unconsciously, as in the case of the primitive or child.

Primitive Techniques

Exaggeration
Spontaneity
Activeness
Simplicity
Distortion
Flatness
Irregularity
Roundness
Colorfulness

EXPRESSIONISM

Closely related to the primitive style is expressionism; the only major difference between the two is intention. Frequently the exaggerated detail of the primitive is part of an outreach toward representationalism, a sincere attempt to make things look more real, an attempt that fails because of the lack of techniques. Expressionism uses exaggeration purposefully to distort reality. It is a style that seeks to provoke emotion, whether religious or intellectual. Part of its roots lies in the early Christian conflict between the iconodule and the iconoclast. Early Christianity was a new religion greatly influenced by the Hebrew prohibition of image worship which was associated with false gods. The compromise was an abstraction from reality that was still recognizable. The distortion, the emphasis on emotion, makes the Byzantine a typical example of expressionistic style. Wherever it ex-



ists, the style reaches beyond the rational to the mystical, to an inner vision of reality, charged with passion and heightened by feeling.

Expressionism has always dominated the work of individual artists or whole schools, whose work can be characterized by great feeling and spirituality. The Middle Ages, for instance, produced one of the greatest examples of the style, Gothic. It was a period in history fraught with defects, typified by the Crusades, a two-hundred-year exercise in futility. But through it all, in a continuing gesture of devotion to God and a reaching for eternal salvation in heaven, the people joined their efforts to build their churches as an offering of their town and

city. Supervised by master builders and craftsmen, each citizen of a town labored anonymously to make some lasting contribution to his God. The result was a slow but passionate development of the Gothic cathedral, whose pointed arches, vaulting, and flying buttresses opened up space for light to come in through stained glass windows. The attenuated upreach through the intense use of verticality of line gave anyone standing inside a sensation of being levitated, of being lifted up to heaven.

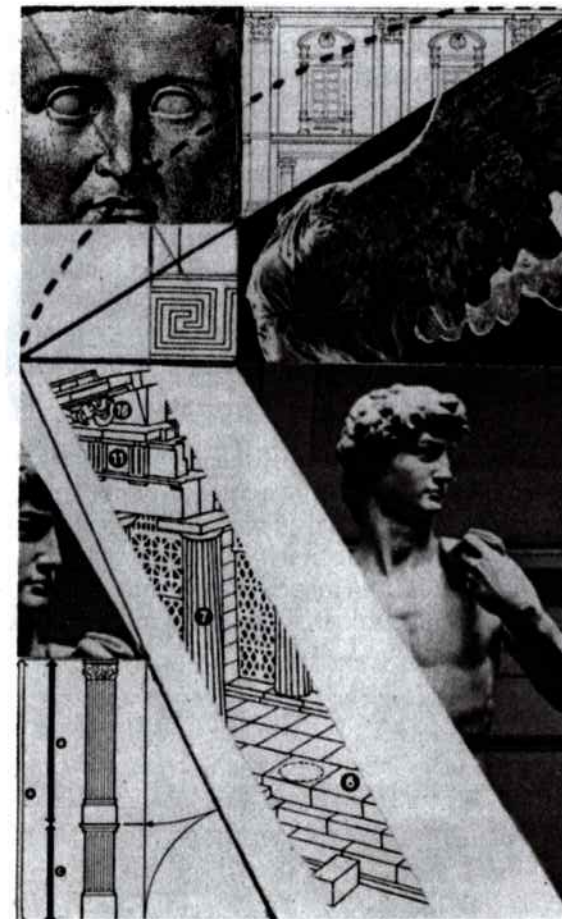
The same intensity of feeling is present in the landscapes and portraits of El Greco and Kokoschka, whose work is strongly related to the mosaics of the Byzantine Empire. Whether in the Gothic or Byzantine or the work of individual artists, expressionistic style is present when the artist or designer is seeking to evoke a maximum emotional response from the viewer.

Expressionistic Techniques

Exaggeration
Spontaneity
Activeness
Complexity
Roundness
Boldness
Variation
Distortion
Irregularity
Juxtaposition
Verticality

CLASSICISM

The emotionalism of expressionism is a direct contrast to the rationality of design methodology typical of Greek and Roman art, which produced the prototypic visual style of classicism. In its purest form, classical style derives its inspiration from two sources. First, it is influenced by a love of nature, which was idealized by the Greeks to a kind of super reality. Instead of seeing themselves, as the Judeo-Christians did, as the emissaries of God on earth, they worshipped many gods with varying and specialized powers as supermen, often in pursuit of extremely worldly pleasures. The Greeks searched for pure truth in their philosophy and science, and here lay the second sources for the classical style. They formalized their art through mathematics,



developing a formula for guiding design decisions called the Golden Mean. The visual elegance they sought was tied to this system, but the rigidity it produced was heightened by their perfection of execution and softened by the warming effects of the decorative sculpture, the painting and the artifacts that enhanced their formula understructure. The Greeks sought beauty in reality. They glorified man and his natural environment. They cherished thought. Their efforts have produced a visual style with rationality and logic in art and design.

Greece and Rome were the source of the "Renaissance," a period whose name meant just that, a rebirth of the classical tradition. The

fifteenth-century Italian scholars and artists studied every treasured remnant of those cultures, and under their influence, turned their attention away from the Christian themes of the Middle Ages to humanism. Although the artists and craftsmen were focused on the Greco-Roman version of classical style, the Renaissance was, in fact, an individual expression of the same theme. Like their predecessors, they admired reality, and through the development of perspective and a unique way to treat light in painting, they succeeded in their painting in replicating the environment as though it were reflected in a mirror. It is no coincidence that the first glimmerings of the future invention of photography originated in the Renaissance in the form of the camera obscura, a plaything used to reproduce the environment on a wall in a darkened room.

In both the fifteenth and the sixteenth centuries, the visual artist left his anonymous role to be recognized, not only as an individual, but as a master, whose education had to be that of a classical scholar. Perfection was, then, as it will always be, associated with the classical style. Like the Greco-Roman culture, the Renaissance was a great watershed of ideas, artistic and philosophical, a period of great genius.

Classical Techniques

Harmony
Simplicity
Accuracy
Symmetry
Sharpness
Monochromaticity
Depth
Consistency
Stasis
Unity

THE EMBELLISHED STYLE

The embellished style is one that emphasizes the softening of hard edges with discursive visual techniques to produce a warming and elegant effect. Not only is the style itself rich in its complexities of design, but it is associated with wealth and power. The grandiose effects it can produce are an abandonment of reality for theatrical decoration, the world of fantasy. In other words, the nature of the style is often florid and overstated, the perfect setting for emperor or king living without concern for much beyond his own indulgences. There



are many periods and schools of art and design that can be grouped under the overall identification of embellishment: Art Nouveau, Victorian, Late Roman. In each case, the designs are typically grandiose, with endless surface decoration, seemingly ruled by the dictum: the most desirable connection between two dots is a curved line.

No school is more representative of the qualities of this style than the Baroque. This period served as a bridge between the Renaissance and the modern era, spreading its style from its Italian origins north of the Alps to Flanders, Germany, to England, to France, to central Europe, to Spain and, carried by Catholic missionaries, to Latin America and the Far East. While the Renaissance was both Italian and,

for the most part, homogeneous. Baroque art is a very inadequate, generalized category under which to group so vast and varied a period of creative expression covering the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. But inadequate though it may be, it does describe a time of anachronism, of great wealth juxtaposed with great poverty. There certainly seemed to be no premium on objectivity or even reality at any level.

The lushness of Baroque certainly seems to bear little relationship to the Victorian period, and yet they both share the same stylistic category. Clearly their inspiration for embellishment differs. For one culture, unrestrained decoration was the symbolic posture of power and glory, while for the Victorian period, it was more of an orgy of homey curliques.

Embellished Techniques

Complexity
Intricacy
Exaggeration
Roundness
Boldness
Fragmentation
Variation
Colorfulness
Activeness
Brightness

FUNCTIONALITY

While functionality has been associated primarily with contemporary design, it is, in fact, as old as the first pot that was ever made to hold water. It is a design methodology most closely connected to the rule of utility and economic consideration. The advent of the Industrial Revolution and technological development has linked the philosophy of simple means to the natural capability of the machine, even though the simple means has always been available to making and manufacture. The major change from other visual stylistic approaches and the functional style is the seeking of beauty in the thematic and expressive qualities of the basic and underlying structure in any visual work.

Finding aesthetic value in workmanship is not new. It is typical of any craftsman who delights in the imperfections that have to do with the struggle between him and his medium. The very people who first developed a modern philosophy of craftsmanship, the Pre-Raphael-



ites, did it on the basis of rejecting the whole concept of manufacture by machine. In England, led by William Morris, the Arts and Crafts Council espoused a philosophy that held "Truth in making is making by hand, and making by hand is making by joy." They chose to turn their backs on the distasteful reality of mass production. But whether or not they liked it was unimportant—the machine was here to stay. The first group that really tried to understand the implications of the machine and tried to cope with its potential was a loose confederation of architects, designers, and craftsmen, who lived and worked in Germany before World War I. They called themselves the "Deutscher Werkbund," and they attempted to become more aware of the inner meaning and quality of what they designed by seeking the "Sachlich-

keit" or thingness of their materials. Their probing for a means to reconcile the artist and the machine became the inspiration for the "Bauhaus," an art school started by Walter Gropius and a distinguished group of teachers in Germany directly after the ending of the war, in 1919. Its purpose was to pursue new forms and new solutions to man's basic needs as well as his aesthetic ones. The Bauhaus' curriculum returned to fundamentals, the basic materials, the basic rules of design. And the questions they dared to ask led to new definitions of beauty in the unadorned and practical aspects of the functional.

Functional Techniques

Simplicity
Symmetry
Angularity
Predictability
Consistency
Sequentiality
Unity
Repetition
Economy
Subtlety
Flatness
Regularity
Sharpness
Monochromaticity
Mechanicalness

There is much more to the structure and meaning of style than can be covered solely in terms of categories or the techniques that figure largely in developing those categories. For purposes of aesthetic definition or practical application, simplification of both style concepts and variations of techniques is helpful in understanding and controlling the visual means. But simplification does not affect the complexity of visual literacy. The categorization exercise is purely arbitrary and the numbers of techniques are endless in their subtle variations. As they are treated here, they are only a hint of the vast resources of our visual vocabulary. But the inexperienced, the visually illiterate, must have a point of departure that will work, and knowledge of the character of all the components of visual communication offers a means for seeking design methods that offer some assurance of sound solution.

EXERCISES

1. Do an abstract drawing or collage that expresses a basic style category and combines the visual techniques most prominent in it. You can use collage techniques, but avoid representational visual information.
2. Using the above exercise as inspiration shoot some photographs or find reproductions of photographs which express the style being analyzed.
3. Make a list of specific examples that identify the five different visual styles in any of the following areas: architecture, clothes design, interior design. If possible, find examples that illustrate your assumptions. Can you do the same with classes of life in nature such as trees or birds?
4. Make a sketch plan for how you might photograph the same subject in a variety of styles. Review the techniques you would use.